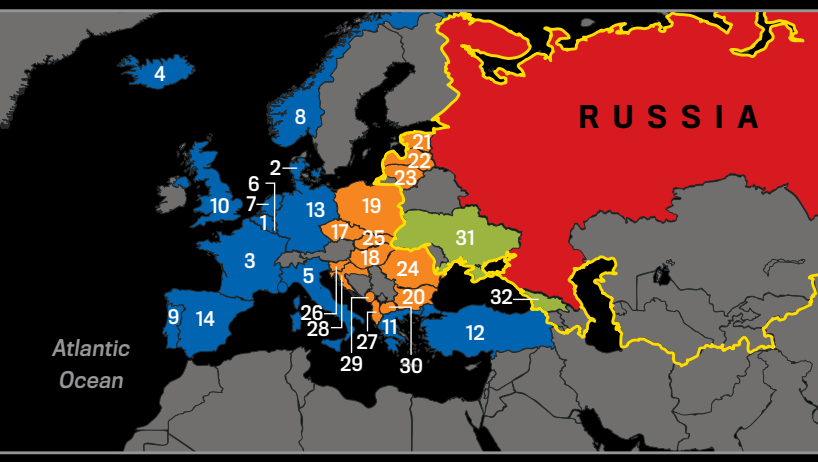


— USSR (till 1991)

NATO ENCIRCLEMENT

NATO's expansion after 1991 has been aided by the inclusion of several former eastern bloc countries

● 1949-1982
1. Belgium 2. Denmark
3. France 4. Iceland 5. Italy
6. Luxembourg 7. Netherlands
8. Norway 9. Portugal
10. United Kingdom 11. Greece
12. Turkey 13. Germany
14. Spain 15. Canada
16. United States

● AFTER 1991
17. Czech Republic
18. Hungary 19. Poland
20. Bulgaria 21. Estonia
22. Latvia 23. Lithuania
24. Romania 25. Slovakia
26. Slovenia 27. Albania
28. Croatia 29. Montenegro
30. North Macedonia

● KNOCKING AT NATO's DOOR
31. Ukraine, 32. Georgia

rise as Poroshenko pushes for Ukraine's integration with Europe and NATO.

FEB. 2015

Pro-Russian separatists begin uprising in east Ukraine's Donetsk and Luhansk. France and Germany broker Minsk 2 pact where Ukraine agrees to decentralisation of powers to these regions.



APR. 2019

Volodymyr Zelenskyy, a former comedian, wins Ukrainian presidential election. He is pro-West and disputes the terms of the Minsk agreement with Russia; declares Ukraine will join NATO.

JUNE 2020

NATO upgrades Ukraine to 'enhanced opportunities partner'. Between late 2020 and end-2021, Russia builds up forces along Ukraine's eastern and northern borders. Putin warns NATO to keep off Ukraine.

FEB. 21, 2022

Russia recognises Donetsk and Luhansk as independent regions, sends in troops to reinforce territorial claims. On **Feb. 24,** Russia invades Ukraine.

America's concern was that Russia would not stop at these demands. Putin seemed intent on restoring Russia's past glory. As a perceptive report this January by the think-tank Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), authored by Seth C. Jones, its vice president, and Philip C. Wasielewski, a former CIA officer, noted: "Russian annexation of some or all of Ukraine would increase Russian manpower, industrial capacity and natural resources to a level that could make it a global threat. The US and Europe cannot make this mistake again."

US President Joe Biden refused to come to any agreement with Russia, saying there were no recent moves to admit Ukraine or Georgia to NATO. Germany and France had in 2008 made their opposition to Ukraine's entry to NATO explicit, effectively blocking any such move. Ashley Tellis, senior fellow at the international think-tank Carnegie Endowment for International Peace (CEIP), says, "These countries want to join European institutions because they have horrible memories of being under Soviet rule for 70 years. My view is that the threat of NATO expansion is just an excuse by Putin to go about his ambition of recovering whatever he can of the erstwhile Soviet Union." The US administration then warned the world that Russia was on the brink of an invasion, which Shiv Shankar Menon, former National Security Advisor, says, "ironically, goaded Putin into invading Ukraine—else he would seem chicken". P.S. Raghavan, a former chairman of the National Security Advisory Board, agrees: "The war is a result of a basic failure of diplomacy by key NATO members."

EUROPE STRIKES BACK

While invading Ukraine, Putin gambled on a shock-and-awe approach that he hoped would bring Zelensky to his knees in the first week itself, with minimum civilian casualties. It also relied on the assumption that a disunited Europe and disengaged US would have no stomach to join battle. With Russia sitting on $600 billion in forex reserves, its president had enough treasure to withstand any sanctions imposed. "Putin is willing to take enormous risks and is tactically smart," says Tellis, "though capable of strategic blunders—as Hitler was." His military calculations seem to have initially gone off the mark, with the Ukrainians putting up stiff resistance.